



A community of strangers

1 Considered as a social experience unique to the late twentieth century, rock festivals have shaped how many baby boomers¹ think about their place in the world: for those too young to have experienced a world war, too suburban² to have been in a riot, and too middle class
5 to have raged against societal inequities, attending a rock festival is sometimes the only way they have, or think they have, directly participated in history. Also, rock crowds differ from mobs³ and armies (that is, masses of people threatening violence) in that people feel safe in them even when they aren't. In fact, the rock festival crowd is
10 often a place, and maybe the only place, where people feel a sense of community with strangers and where they are able to briefly retrieve what industrial society has taken away: that is, a sense of interpersonal intimacy that's been lost to the internet. [...]

15 In short, there is something indefinably positive, something sexy and proud about a rock crowd that defies logic. The real conditions of a rock festival's material existence are not pretty. But the imagined ones are beautiful beyond compare. Rock festivals might even be what has been called a "temporary autonomous zone" – that is, an area where official control has temporarily been ceded to a nongovernmental, nonofficial,
20 nonhierarchical force: to the people, as it were.

*Half a Million Strong: Crowds and Power
from Woodstock to Coachella, 2018*

1. **baby boomers**: people born in the post-war period between 1946 and 1964

2. **suburban**: from middle-class areas outside of cities

3. **mob**: a group of people causing trouble